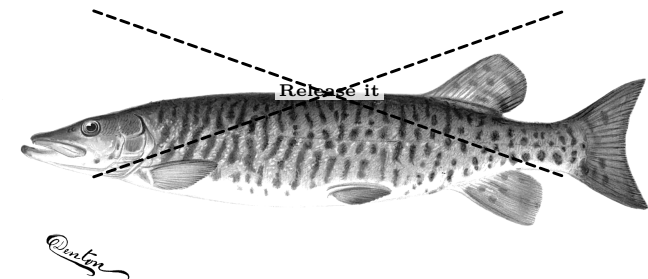


Cooking Muskellunge

Esox masquinongy — in the kitchen

Do not eat it — and here is the reason, in numbers



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Not a fish to eat, and this is the one sheet in the guide that says so. •••••
Mercury	Muskellunge sit at the top of the food chain and live for fifteen to twenty years, so they accumulate more mercury than anything else in the lake. Wisconsin's statewide guidance is do not eat for women under 50 and children under 15, and one serving per <i>month</i> for everybody else. No other species in this guide carries a do-not-eat line.
Scarcity	Musky are not among the species the DNR lists as common in either lake. A musky here is a rare, old, slow-growing fish.
Regulation	40 in minimum, one per day, open water only. A legal musky is a very large animal.
If you must	The flesh is white and firm, comparable to pike and with the same Y-bone structure. <i>see the Cooking Northern Pike sheet</i>
Better outcome	Photograph it in the net, measure it, and let it go.

If you catch one

1. **Confirm it is a musky and not a pike** before you do anything else. Dark marks on a light body, the lower half of both cheek and gill cover scaleless, six to nine pores per side of the lower jaw. *see the **Muskellunge** sheet*
2. **Measure it in the net, in the water.** Under 40 in it goes back regardless.
3. **Keep it horizontal and wet.** A large musky is injured by its own weight in air. Support the belly.
4. **Unhook it in the water** with long pliers and jaw spreaders. Cut the hook if it is awkward.
5. **Revive it properly** — upright, moving forward, until it swims off under its own power. A big musky may need several minutes.
6. **Photograph it low over the water**, so that if it kicks free it lands in the lake and not on the deck.

Bones and what to watch for

Same as pike	Y-bones above the lateral line in the front of each fillet, floating and un-pullable.
But	The bone structure is not the reason to leave it. The mercury load and the rarity of the fish are.
Handling	Teeth as bad as a pike's on a much larger animal. Jaw spreaders and long pliers, always.
Gear	A landing net big enough for the fish, ready before you hook one.

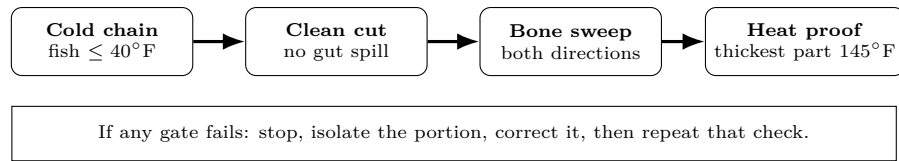
Cooking it

Method	How
—	This sheet does not carry recipes, and that is deliberate. If you want a large white-fleshed fish for the table from these waters, keep a legal northern pike instead: it eats as well, it is far more abundant, it grows faster, and it carries a fraction of the mercury.

Why this sheet exists

It would be easy to leave musky out of a cooking guide entirely. But somebody will eventually catch a legal one and want to know, and the honest answer is a number: Wisconsin's health guidance puts musky in a category by itself, alongside no other inland species. That is worth knowing before the fish is in the cooler rather than after.

Prove the meal before serving



Ask now	Pass condition	If it fails
Is the fish still cold?	Firm, clean-smelling flesh at or below 40 °F.	If time above 40 °F is uncertain, discard; do not try to “cook safety back in.”
Did the knife enter gut or gall?	No green stain, fecal material, or sour odor on edible flesh.	Cut away a generous contaminated margin; wash hands, knife, and board before touching clean meat.
Are the portions actually boneless?	Bright light plus two slow fingertip passes, head-to-tail and tail-to-head.	Return the portion to the clean board; trim or recut. Never rely on batter or sauce to hide a bone.
Is the center done?	A clean instant-read probe enters sideways into the thickest piece and reads 145 °F.	Keep cooking in short increments; clean the probe before rechecking.

Final proof

Set one finished portion on a clean plate, split its thickest point, and confirm opaque, separating flakes with no translucent core. Record the time and temperature once when learning a new pan, oven, or portion thickness. Cool leftovers shallowly and refrigerate within two hours. The proof is the measured center, not a timer, crust color, or confident guess.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For muskellunge: **do not eat** for women under 50 and children under 15; **one serving per month** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR's Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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